# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

**America's** consumer prices rose by 3.2% in the year to February, up from 3.1% in January. Core prices—which exclude energy and food—increased by 0.4% month on month in February, the second consecutive month the figure has exceeded expectations. The data will inform rate-setters at the Federal Reserve, due to meet next week.

**Kenya** will not deploy police officers to Haiti until a new government is formed there, according to Kenyan officials. The decision came after Ariel Henry, **Haiti's** embattled prime minister, resigned following talks with regional leaders in Jamaica. Mr Henry had been in Kenya to finalise an agreement to send 1,000 officers to Haiti, when gangs overran Port-au-Prince, the capital.

**Klaus Iohannis**, Romania's president, entered the race to succeed Jens Stoltenberg as secretary-general of **NATO**. Mr Iohannis will challenge Mark Rutte, the Dutch prime minister, who has struggled to gain support from all 32 of the alliance's members. America, Britain, France and Germany favour Mr Rutte. But as Russia's war with Ukraine continues, Mr Iohannis's emphasis on eastern Europe's "valuable contribution" to NATO could strike a chord.

**Ukrainian drone strikes** caused serious damage to a **Russian** refinery near the city of Nizhny Novgorod, roughly 430km (270 miles) east of Moscow. The NORSI refinery produces around 6% of Russia's refined crude oil every year. Meanwhile two groups of Russian rebels operating from Ukraine staged a series of border raids into the Belgorod and Kursk regions of western Russia.

A ship carrying nearly 200 tonnes of food set sail for **Gaza** from Cyprus. The vessel's departure is the first step towards opening a

sea route to deliver desperately needed aid to the besieged enclave. Earlier Israel launched further air strikes against targets in Lebanon. The Israel Defence Forces said the action was retaliation for attacks by Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militant group.

The governor of the **Bank of Japan**, Ueda Kazuo, said that the Japanese economy is recovering despite some difficulties. He cited a "weakness in some household spending data" but noted that business investment is increasing steadily. Traders widely interpreted Mr Ueda's remarks as offering a marginally less positive view of Japan's economy than expected, leading the yen to fall slightly.

A **Romanian** court approved a request by **Britain** to extradite Andrew Tate, a misogynistic influencer, and his brother to the country, after their trial in Romania ends. They were detained in Romania after a British court issued a warrant for their arrest over alleged sexual crimes. The pair face charges of human trafficking and rape in Romania. They deny all charges.

**Figure of the day:** $13,000, the fee that Celestis Memorial Spaceflights, a Houston-based firm, charges to send people's cremated ashes to the moon. Read the full story.

*In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.*

Photo: Getty Images

## America’s slowly slowing inflation

The headline figures may look worrying. Data released on Tuesday showed that consumer prices in America rose by 0.4% month on month in February, more than in January. A steady increase in petrol prices was probably mainly responsible. But what really matters is underlying inflationary momentum, revealed by core prices, which strip out energy and food costs. These rose by 0.4% month on month, the same as in January.

By itself, mostly static inflation will not move the needle for markets. But it is likely to reinforce investors’ belief that the Federal Reserve will start cutting interest rates in June. Last week Jerome Powell, the Fed’s chairman, said he was “not far” from having the confidence to cut rates. A benign inflation report would move him a little bit closer.

Photo: AP

# The enduring problem of Fukushima

In August TEPCO, a Japanese electricity company, started releasing wastewater from its Fukushima nuclear power plant into the Pacific Ocean. The plant's disastrous meltdown in 2011 still casts a long shadow: though the treated wastewater is now barely radioactive, the decision was widely unpopular.

The UN's International Atomic Energy Agency sanctioned the plan in the summer. On Tuesday Rafael Grossi, the agency's head, arrived in Japan again to review the project. After his three-day visit he is likely to reassure government officials and locals that no environmental damage has been caused. Last week IAEA experts reported that levels of radioactivity in the water remain "far below the operational limit".

The real challenge, though, is decommissioning the power plant, which still holds around 880 tonnes of radioactive fuel-debris in its crippled reactors. In January TEPCO delayed its clean-up plan—meant to start in 2021—for the third time. Many worry that the promised completion deadline of 2051 now looks far-fetched.

Photo: AP

## Biden hosts Poland’s divided leaders

Poland joined NATO a quarter of a century ago. That membership now seems more important than ever. Poles watched in horror as Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine, which is not a member, in 2022. In a recent poll almost half of respondents said they expected Russia to attack their country in the next few years.

Last year Poland raised defence spending to 4% of GDP—twice the target for NATO members. President Joe Biden will probably laud that commitment when he hosts Poland’s president, Andrzej Duda, and its new prime minister, Donald Tusk, at the White House on Tuesday. The joint invitation is symbolic: the two come from bitterly opposed parties. Mr Duda said it shows the strength of the Polish-American relationship “regardless of who rules in both countries.”

But some Republicans are wavering on their country’s commitment to defending eastern European allies. Poles will be hoping that America’s support will hold whoever wins November’s presidential election.

Photo: Getty Images

## Argentines' patience is wearing thin

In January Argentina's annual inflation rate was a staggering 254.2%, the highest since 1991. Yet the country also recorded its first fiscal surplus in nearly 12 years. For some, that second part is evidence enough that President Javier Milei's pursuit of fiscal balance—including a 54% devaluation of the peso and the end of energy and transport subsidies—is gradually working. For others, though, the economic pill is too bitter to swallow.

They will get a sense of how long they must keep taking Mr Milei's medicine on Tuesday, when inflation data for February are due. The president predicts a lower monthly rate of 15% (January's was 20.6%). But that is still very high. And Mr Milei admits that "it will take some time" before the country sees the benefits of his reforms. But with 57.4% of Argentines now below the poverty line—the most in two decades—many do not feel they can wait.

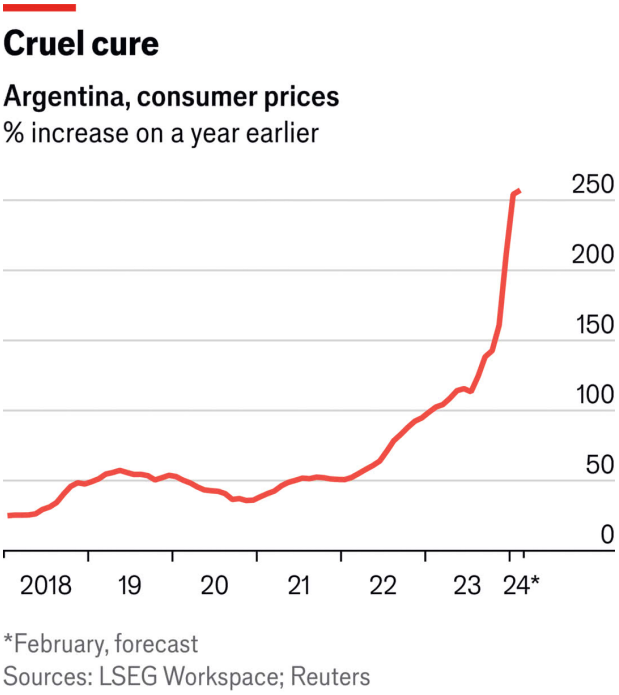

Photo: Ulf Anderson/Getty Images

# Gabriel García Márquez's last novel

Gabriel García Márquez—a Colombian Nobel-prizewinning novelist who died in 2014—once said memory was his primary source of material. That may explain why, suffering from dementia towards the end of his life, he insisted that his final novella should never be published.

His sons eventually decided otherwise. “Until August” will be unveiled on Tuesday, in the run-up to the tenth anniversary of the author’s death. With any such “lost” work, the question arises of whether it should have been found again. Márquez’s adoring public will decide for themselves, but many early reviews of this slight book have been mixed at best. The master of magical realism here conjured a plot that seems to be a variation on those in low-grade erotic fiction: a married woman on an annual pilgrimage takes a different lover each year. It’s possible that, even in his sadly diminished state, Márquez saw his final book with clearer eyes than his children chose to.

## Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [email protected]. We’ll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

**Tuesday:** Which is the largest of the Channel Islands, which sit between England and France?

**Monday:** The Institutional Revolutionary Party ruled which country continuously from 1929 to 2000?

*If someday they say of me that in my work I have contributed something to the welfare and happiness of my fellow man, I shall be satisfied.*

*George Westinghouse*